

### 141. *False to His Dharma: Article*<sup>1</sup>

The intelligentsia of India are behind those of no other country in talents or power of understanding. They should use their talents and all their new knowledge to enquire into the causes of the appalling poverty of the rural population and discover and work out remedies. Until a more satisfactory solution is found it is their sacred and urgent duty to examine, and if found even in a measure good, try the remedy of Khadi. If they find that hand-spinning is the only supplementary cottage industry that can be taken up by large masses of people normally engaged in agriculture whose time is available for other work during a great part of the year, they are bound to carry that conviction into practice and protect the Khadi industry themselves and call upon the State and people to do likewise. Any other course would be contrary to *dharma*. In the course of a lecture delivered by Mr. P. J. Thomas,<sup>2</sup> University Professor of Economics in Madras, the problem of rural reconstruction was approached with commendable warmth of feeling. The professor did not mince matters despite the thoroughly official auspices under which he spoke. His Excellency, the Governor of Madras occupied the chair and among those who were present to lend importance to the meeting were the Vice-Chancellor of the University,<sup>3</sup> the principals of three big colleges, at least one minister in charge of a portfolio of Government, and the head of the Department of Agriculture.

'In the India of the present day,' the professor said, 'the problem urgently needing our attention is the appalling poverty and distressing backwardness of our teeming population. Such poverty and backwardness exist both in the countryside and in

<sup>1</sup> *Young India*, 22 November 1928.

<sup>2</sup> P. J. Thomas; b. 1895; educationist; Professor of Economics, Ceylon University College, Colombo, 1924–27, and Madras University, 1927–42; member and President, Indian Economic Association, 1937–38; member, Madras Legislative Council, 1937–42; Chairman, Handloom Industry Committee, Government of India, 1942; Economic Adviser, Department of Finance, 1943–49; member, Indian delegation to the inaugural session of the UNO, San Francisco, 1945; member and treasurer, Travancore-Cochin Provincial Congress Committee, 1951–52; Chairman, Cottage Industries Committee, 1950–51, and Banking Enquiry Commission, Travancore-Cochin Government, 1956; member, Rajya Sabha, 1957–62; publications include: *Mercantilism and East India Trade*, *Rural Indebtedness*, *Prohibition in Salem District*, and *Evolution of Indian Finance*; d. 1965.

<sup>3</sup> K. Ramunni Menon; b. 1872; educationist; entered the Madras Education Department, 1898; Professor of Zoology, Presidency College, Madras, 1910; retired, 1927; Vice-Chancellor, Madras University, 1928–34; life-member, Madras University Senate; represented Madras University at the Congress of the Universities of the Empire in Edinburgh, 1931; Chairman, Inter-University Board, 1932–33; member, Council of State, 1934–36; d. 1949.

the town; in the country, it is due to the unremunerative character of agriculture, our predominant occupation; and in the towns where poverty is no less intense and perhaps even more poignant, it is connected mainly with the decay of our handicrafts and the slow progress of our manufacturing industries.’ ‘The neglect of agriculture and the countryside is’, he warned, ‘bound to disintegrate civilization and ruin kingdoms. The invention of the steam engine gave a phenomenal advantage to machine industry and made industrial countries wealthy and powerful, but today such countries are in a pitiable plight owing to various new developments.’

Mr. Thomas pointed out, that ‘our agriculturists are almost entirely petty peasants cultivating small holdings. The entry of India into the welter of world economy caused by all the recent changes in long distance transport has in various ways worsened the position of the Indian agriculturists.’ In tracing the causes of the miserable condition of the people of India, Mr. Thomas did not, happily, forget the loss of supplementary income from domestic handicraft due to the competition of machine industry. But, alas, beyond mentioning it, he did not care to examine it further or utter a single suggestion about it. It is truly remarkable, this conspiracy of silence on the part of Commissions and even University professors. Yet Mr. Thomas’ words are emphatic and suggestive enough: ‘If the Indian economist does not wholeheartedly give his attention to these pressing problems, he will be false to his *dharma* and unworthy of his profession, for it is his duty to study the economic evils of the community and to suggest suitable remedies.’

## 142. Statement on Subramania Bharati's Poems<sup>1</sup>

### THE VOICE OF INDIA RENASCENT

#### *The Choice for the Law Member*

At question time on Tuesday, the Law Member<sup>2</sup> was asked by more than one member of the Council what steps he had taken to give effect to the opinion of the House on the seizure of the poems of Subramania Bharati. He replied that instructions had been issued to the police not to make any more seizures until further orders. We should be grateful for small mercies. But if the Government really respected the opinion of the House it should do more than issue instructions for the future. We know that all available copies at the printers and the publishers had been already seized. There is nothing much further to do. Really speaking, a

<sup>1</sup> *Hindu*, 1 December 1928, and *New India*, 4 December 1928.

<sup>2</sup> C. P. Ramaswami Aiyar. For biographical note see Volume I, p. 162, note 9.